# M365-12 · OneDrive Appropriate Use & Institutional Data Boundary

*Which files belong in a person's OneDrive, which belong to the organization, and where the line falls.*

| Field | Value |
|---|---|
| Document ID | M365-12 |
| Version | 1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman |
| Catalogue domain | A. Microsoft 365 |
| Operating tier | Tier 1 — the conversation happens at the front door. Remediation is Tier 2. |
| Review cycle | Annually. |
| Related existing policy | Your shared storage policy and your sensitive data disposal policy, if you have them. |

## 1. Purpose

Every member of staff has a OneDrive. This document says what it is for, and — more usefully — what it is not for, so that the organization's records do not end up somewhere only one person can reach.

A common case: a departing senior member of staff holds a considerable number of organization files in their personal OneDrive, because it "started when I was a consultant here". That is an entirely reasonable thing to have happened: nobody ever told them otherwise, and there was no rule to follow. Resolving it means standing up a SharePoint site and re-permissioning it by hand, during a transition, under time pressure.

> **The point of this document**
> Not to reprimand anybody. It is to make the next departure a five-minute checklist item instead of a rescue project — and to make it easy for a person to do the right thing without having to guess what the right thing is.

## 2. The rule

> **The boundary, in one line**
> If the organization would need this file after you left, it does not belong only in your OneDrive.
> That is the whole test. It does not require anybody to classify data, read a policy, or know what a records schedule is — and it produces the right answer almost every time it is applied honestly.

## 3. What belongs where

| | Your OneDrive | A departmental SharePoint site |
|---|---|---|
| Use it for | Drafts in progress, your own working notes, your personal copies, anything genuinely yours. | Anything the department relies on, anything more than one person needs, anything that must outlive your role. |
| Examples | A draft you are not ready to share. Your notes from a meeting. A reference copy of something published elsewhere. | Contracts. Budgets. Committee papers. Procedures. Anything a successor would need on their first day. |
| Who can reach it | You, plus anyone you have shared with individually. | The team, by permission, with a named site owner. |
| What happens if you go | It is retained but nobody knows what is in it, and access is a request rather than a right (ACC-01 §7.3). | Nothing. The department carries on. |
| Backed up | Yes, both are. | Yes. |

One nuance worth stating: a draft becoming a record is a normal and gradual thing. The moment to move it is when somebody else first needs it, not when it is finished. Waiting for “finished” is how documents stay in a OneDrive for four years.

## 4. Why this matters more than it sounds

- Continuity. A file only you can reach is a single point of failure with a person attached to it. Illness, leave and departure all have the same effect.
- Records obligations. Some organization records must be retained and producible. That is not possible if their location is unknown.
- Sensitive data. Payroll, applicant, conduct and health records carry obligations that individual OneDrive sharing was never designed to satisfy (M365-15, and the existing Information Security policy).
- Cost of the rescue. A case like that consumes IT and senior staff time during a transition. The preventive version is one conversation at onboarding.

## 5. Sharing from OneDrive

1. Prefer moving the file to the departmental site over sharing it from your OneDrive. Sharing solves today; moving solves permanently.
2. Where sharing is right, share with named people rather than with “anyone with the link”. Anonymous links outlive their purpose and cannot be audited to a person.
3. Set an expiry on any external share, and never share a folder when a file will do (M365-14).
4. Never share anything of a sensitive class from a personal OneDrive. Move it first.
5. Review what you are sharing once a quarter. Most people are sharing more than they remember.

## 6. What happens at separation

Stated here so it is not a surprise, because it is the moment the rule pays for itself.

- The manager receives delegated access to the OneDrive for 30 days.
- Within that window, everything institutional is MOVED into the departmental SharePoint site, where the retention floor (two years in this catalogue, M365-16) actually applies to it.
- What is left in the OneDrive after the window is personal or superseded material, and carries no retention obligation.
- If the boundary in §2 has been observed, that window is a formality. If it has not, it is a scramble — and it is the leaver's colleagues who do the scrambling.

> **Why the move is the default, and why it is the whole point of this document**
>
> It is natural to assume that a leaver's OneDrive can simply be left in place — unlicensed, untouched, available if anyone ever needs it. That is not how the platform behaves, and the difference is the reason this document matters.
>
> An unlicensed OneDrive goes read-only after 60 unlicensed days and is archived on its 93rd, and beyond that a cumulative 365-day nonpayment clock carries a deletion risk. Retention policies and legal holds ARE honoured through the archived state, but only while archive billing is enabled — unpaid, the content is at risk at 365 days despite the hold. Reassigning the OneDrive to a new owner does not help: Microsoft states that enforcement does not use the owner property to validate licensing, and that changing it puts the site in an unsupported state.
>
> There are paid routes that do preserve an unlicensed OneDrive properly — a longer tenant active-storage period, or archive billing at $0.05/GB/month — and they are set out with their costs in M365-16 §5. Separately, Microsoft states that this enforcement does not apply to EDU, GCC or DoD customers; if your tenant qualifies, that may remove the constraint entirely (M365-16 §5.2).
>
> None of which changes the recommendation. Moving the records costs nothing, depends on no billing toggle staying correct for two years, and is what Microsoft itself advises for a OneDrive with no active owner. More to the point, a personal site named after someone who left is invisible to the colleagues who need what is in it. Everything in §2 exists to make that move small.
>
> Verified against Microsoft Learn in August 2026. Re-check before relying on it.

## 7. Remediation — finding institutional data in a OneDrive

This will be found routinely, and the handling should be unremarkable rather than adversarial.

1. Talk to the person first. In nearly every case they will move it willingly once they know where it should go; owners often raise it themselves once they know there is a right place.
2. Identify or create the destination: an existing departmental site, or a new one under M365-10 with a named owner.
3. Move rather than copy. Two copies diverge, and the OneDrive copy is the one people keep editing.
4. Confirm permissions on the destination before removing anything from the source.
5. Where the person has left and cannot be asked, the manager decides under §6.

6. Where the content is of a sensitive class and has been shared beyond the department, that is a Tier 4 matter, not a tidy-up (M365-15, GOV-03).

## 8. During the file share retirement

> **A specific risk worth naming**
>
> When old shared drives are retired, and a familiar shared location disappears, the path of least resistance is for people to move its contents into their own OneDrive — which converts a shared departmental store into a set of private ones, silently, and would be a worse outcome than the drives staying.
>
> So M365-13 must land the destination before the source is removed, and this document is the reason. Communications about the retirement should say where things go, not only that the drives are going.
>
> The moment a department asks IT what "going away" means for its files is exactly the moment this risk is live.

## 9. Service levels

| Request | Commitment (per GOV-06) |
|---|---|
| "Where should this go?" | Answered at Tier 1 in the conversation. |
| New departmental site to receive content | P3 under M365-10. |
| Help moving content out of a OneDrive | P3 at Tier 2. |
| Manager delegation on a leaver's OneDrive | Part of the ACC-01 §7 leaver procedure, on the separation date. |
| Sensitive data found shared beyond the department | P1 to Tier 4 (GOV-03). |

## 10. Records

| Record | Held in | Retention |
|---|---|---|
| Remediation moves, with destination | Ticket | 3 years |
| Manager delegations at separation | Ticket | 3 years |
| Sensitive-data findings | Security record (GOV-03) | 7 years |

## 11. Related documents

| ID | Title | Relationship |
|---|---|---|
| Storage Policy | the organization Network Shared Storage Policy (existing) | Already published. This procedure operates under it and should be cross-referenced from it. |
| M365-10 | SharePoint Site Request, Provisioning & Ownership | Where the destination comes from. |

| ID | Title | Relationship |
|---|---|---|
| M365-11 | SharePoint & OneDrive Permission Management | How the destination is permissioned. |
| M365-13 | Legacy File Share Retirement | §8 — the destination must exist before the source goes. |
| M365-14 | External Sharing & Guest Access Governance | Sharing rules in §5. |
| M365-15 | Data Classification & Handling | What “sensitive class” means. |
| ACC-01 | Account Lifecycle | §7.3 retention and the 30-day manager delegation. |
| GOV-06 | Service Commitments | Supplies §9. |

## Appendix A — End-user text

Source text for your internal knowledge base and for onboarding. Format per GOV-05.

| | |
|---|---|
| Your OneDrive | Yours for drafts, working notes and personal copies. It is backed up and it is private to you unless you share something. |
| The one rule | If the organization would need a file after you left, it should not live only in your OneDrive. Put it in your department’s SharePoint site instead. |
| When to move it | When somebody else first needs it — not when it is finished. Waiting for “finished” is how documents stay put for years. |
| Not sure where it goes? | Ask the service desk. It is a thirty-second answer and nobody minds being asked. |
| Sharing | Share with named people rather than “anyone with the link”, and put an expiry on anything going outside the organization. |
| If you are leaving | Your manager gets access to your OneDrive for 30 days so anything the department needs can be moved. If you have followed the rule above, there will be nothing to do. |

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.